

Maša Bešlin

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Employment

FALL 2025– **Postdoctoral Associate in Syntax**, *Georgetown University*.

Education

2019–2025 **Ph.D. in Linguistics**, *University of Maryland*.

THESIS: Lexical categories, (re)categorization and locality in morphosyntax

COMMITTEE: Maria Polinsky & David Embick (co-advisors), Norbert Hornstein, Alexander Williams, Michael Israel

2015–2019 **B.A. in English Language and Literature**, *University of Novi Sad*.

2016 **Erasmus+ Student Mobility Program**, *University of Deusto*.

Research Interests

BROAD syntax and its interfaces with phonology and semantics, cognitive science

NARROW (mixed) categories, locality, raising, ellipsis, case, bare-NP adverbials, structure of the nominal phrase, argument/event structure, grammatical aspect, tense, gender, Mayan, Slavic

Publications

MANUSCRIPTS

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**. Constraining allomorphy with featural adjacency.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**. Reconsidering Phase locality.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**, David Embick, Stefan Ivanović, Predrag Kovačević & Utku Turk. Distinguishing genuine and apparent morphology in lexical processing: A study of prefixed verbs in Serbian.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša & Katherine Howitt**. Island effects in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian: A large-scale acceptability study and generalization in neural language models.

JOURNAL ARTICLES

accepted **Bešlin, Maša**. Apparent voice mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis: non-distinctness, argument structure, and syntactic feature composition. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*.

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Active participles are (deverbal) adjectives. *Journal of Linguistics*, 1–34. DOI: 10.1017/S0022226725000155

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Revisiting passive participles: Category status and internal structure. *Linguistic Inquiry* 54(4), 729–758. DOI: 10.1162/ling_a_00463

BOOK CHAPTERS

- contracted* **Bešlin, Maša.** Building structure and testing constituency. In *The Cambridge Companion to Generative Syntax*. Cambridge University Press.

PROCEEDINGS

- in press* **Bešlin, Maša.** Restricting allomorphy without spell-out opacity. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 56)*.
- in press* **Bešlin, Maša.** Missing verbal structure in BCS agent nominals. In *Proceedings of the Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17)*.
- 2025 **Bešlin, Maša.** On locality conditions for allomorphy and the ordering of interface operations. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 55)*, 67–80. University of Massachusetts Amherst: GLSA.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** On the incompatibility of two types of phases. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 54)*, 79–88. University of Massachusetts Amherst: GLSA.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** DP in a model NP language: Evidence from Serbo-Croatian personal pronouns. In *Proceedings of the Israeli Association for Theoretical Linguistics (IATL 36)*, MIT Working Papers in Linguistics 95.
- 2024 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin.** Word order in Old English embedded clauses: Syntactic instantiation and pragmatic factors. In *Proceedings of ELALT 6*, Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy in Novi Sad.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** Reanalyzing K’iche’ as a tensed language. In J. A. G. Douglas-Tavani & G. Belmar Viernes (eds.), *Proceedings of the Workshop on American Indigenous Languages (WAIL 25)*, UC Santa Barbara Linguistics Department.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** Passive *v*P is not phasal in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. In *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America (PLSA)* 8(1). 5499.
- 2022 **Bešlin, Maša.** Raising as a free syntactic operation: Evidence from Serbian. In P. Kovačević, T. Milićev, & N. Milićević (eds.), *Proceedings of SinFonIJA 14*, Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy in Novi Sad. 63–86. University of Novi Sad: Faculty of Philosophy.
- 2019 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin.** Instrumental: Why it is absent from the clitic system in Serbian/Croatian. In V. Lopičić & B. Mišić-Ilić (eds.), *Proceedings of Jezik, književnost, teorija*. 153–168. University of Niš: Faculty of Philosophy.

EDITED VOLUMES

- in press* **Bešlin, Maša,** Katherine Howitt, Alexandra Krauska, Luisa Seguin, and Juan Uriagereka. *Structured sentences and the computational theory of mind*. Cambridge University Press.

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

- 2025 **Bešlin, Maša & Sadira Lewis.** Exceptives in Thai. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures*. Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.16884105
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** Exceptives in K’iche’. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures*. Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.8059592

- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** Exceptives in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures*. Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.7851016.

Presentations

INVITED TALKS

- 2026 **Bešlin, Maša.** Beyond form and meaning: Investigating abstract morphology in language processing. Presented at:
- *Université du Québec à Montréal*
 - *Masaryk University, Brno*
- 2026 Ruth Kramer & **Maša Bešlin.** The impoverished bishop: Gender, number, and markedness in BCS. *Boston Morphology Workshop*, BU.
- 2025 **Bešlin, Maša.** Mismatches under ellipsis: Syntactic identity and theories of features. *Synsalon*, University of Arizona.
- 2025 **Bešlin, Maša.** Understanding the role of locality in grammar.
- *Friday Speaker Series*, Georgetown University
 - *Oberseminar English Linguistics*, Georg-August-Universität, Göttingen
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** What's up with 'verbal' morphology in BCS agent nominals? *Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17)*, Masaryk University, Brno.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** Is a unified locality theory nothing but a pipe dream? (And why that may not be such a bad thing). *Yale Syntax Reading Group*, Yale University.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** Understanding the role of lexical categories in syntax and semantics. *Institute of Linguistics*, Universität Leipzig.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša.** What's in Universal Grammar? On participles and the inventory of grammatical primitives. Presented at:
- *Princeton Linguistics Colloquium Series*, Princeton University
 - *UW-Madison Language Sciences Colloquium*, UW-Madison
 - *University of Florida Linguistics Colloquium*, University of Florida
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** Domain mismatches in syntax and morphophonology: Consequences for Phase theory. *SynNYU workshop*, NYU.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša.** The Darwin-Plato tension, grammatical primitives, and linguistic principles. *Theoretical and Experimental Syntax Colloquium Series*, Hungarian Research Centre for Linguistics.
- 2021 **Bešlin, Maša.** A Mayan temporal puzzle. *Berkeley Syntax and Semantics Circle*, University of California, Berkeley.

GUEST LECTURES

- 2026 **Bešlin, Maša.** Stress and tone in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian: from phonology to morphology and beyond, *Morphology/phonology Interface graduate seminar*, Georgetown University.
- 2020 **Bešlin, Maša.** Theory and methodology in morphological analysis: A case study of passive participles, *Theoretical Grammar undergraduate seminar*, University of Novi Sad.

CONFERENCE TALKS

- 2026 **Bešlin, Maša** & Ruth Kramer. The features of a bishop: A new approach to gender in BCS. Presented at:
- *Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics* (FASL 35), UCSC
 - *West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics* (WCCFL 44), UNAM
- 2026 **Bešlin, Maša**, Stefan Ivanović, Predrag Kovačević & Utku Turk. The status of Slavic verbal prefixes in mental grammar: Evidence from priming in Bosnian/Croatian/Montenegrin/Serbian. *Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics* (FASL 35), UCSC.
- 2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Accounting for opacity effects at the form interface without the PIC (poster). *North East Linguistics Society 56* (NELS 56), NYU.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. What *actually* delimits the context for allomorphy?. *North East Linguistics Society 55* (NELS 55), Yale University.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Apparent voice mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis: Consequences for the Syntactic Identity Condition. *Form and Analysis in Mayan Linguistics (FAMLi VII)*, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México.
- 2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Domain mismatches in syntax and morphophonology: The case of Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian adjectives (poster). *North East Linguistics Society 54* (NELS 54), Massachusetts Institute of Technology.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Distinct locality domains above and below the 'word' level: Evidence from Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian adjectives. *Rencontres d'Automne de Linguistique Formelle* (RALFE), Université Côte d'Azur.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Temporal interpretation in K'iche'. *Workshop on American Indigenous Languages 25* (WAIL 25), UC Santa Barbara.
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Reanalyzing K'iche' (Mayan) as a Tensed language. *The Society for the Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas* (SSILA) *Annual Meeting* (online).
- 2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Passive *vP* is not phasal in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. *Linguistic Society of America 97th Annual Meeting* (LSA 97), Denver, CO.
- 2022 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Embedded clauses in Old English: Between syntax and pragmatics. *Formal Approaches to Embedding workshop, English Language and Anglophone Literatures Today 6* (ELALT 6), University of Novi Sad.
- 2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On raising-to-subject as a free syntactic operation. *Crossing boundaries: Empirical and theoretical aspects of A-dependencies in complementation workshop, 46th Austrian Linguistics Conference* (ÖLT 46), University of Vienna (online).
- 2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On personal and impersonal *trebati* 'need' in Serbo-Croatian: Implications for raising. *14th Conference on Syntax, Phonology and Language Analysis* (SinFonJA 14), University of Novi Sad (online).
- 2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On the distribution of full object-pronouns in Serbo-Croatian. *16th Annual Meeting of the Slavic Linguistics Society* (SLS 16), University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (online).
- 2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. DP in a model NP language: Evidence from Serbo-Croatian personal pronouns. *36th Annual Conference of the Israel Association for Theoretical Linguistics* (IATL 36), Bar Ilan University (online).

- 2020 **Bešlin, Maša.** Encoding the eventive/resultative/stative distinction on passive participles cross-linguistically. *13th Conference on Syntax, Phonology, and Language Analysis* (SinFonJA 13), Research Institute for Linguistics, Hungarian Academy of Sciences (online).
- 2020 **Bešlin, Maša.** No such thing as a *verbal participle*. *14th European Conference on Formal Description of Slavic Languages* (FDSL 14), University of Leipzig (online), moved to June 2021 due to COVID-19.
- 2020 **Bešlin, Maša.** What's in a name? The syntax of passive participles. *15th Annual Meeting of the Slavic Linguistics Society* (SLS 15), Indiana University Bloomington (online).
- 2019 **Bešlin, Maša.** On the categorial status of the passive participle in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 9*, University of Novi Sad.
- 2019 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin.** Case alternations with temporal bare-NP adverbials in Old English. *English Language and Anglophone Literatures Today 5* (ELALT 5), University of Novi Sad.
- 2018 **Bešlin, Maša.** How often is *subotom*? Some observations on temporal instrumentals in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 8*, University of Novi Sad.
- 2018 **Bešlin, Maša** and Predrag Kovačević. An argument in favor of a rescue-by-PF-deletion analysis of P-stranding under sluicing in Serbo-Croatian. *EGG School Open Podium*, University of Banja Luka.
- 2018 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin.** Instrumental: A curious gap in the clitic system. *Jezik, književnost, teorija*, University of Niš.
- 2017 **Bešlin, Maša.** The case of temporal bare-NP adverbials in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 7*, University of Novi Sad.

Grants & Scholarships

- submitted* Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowship
TITLE: Morphological structure in real-time language comprehension
SUPERVISORS: Pavel Caha & Jakub Dotlačil
- 2022–2024 College of Arts and Humanities Summer Fellowship, UMD
- 2023 Southeast European Studies Association Travel Grant
- 2022 College of Arts and Humanities Graduate Student Travel Award, UMD
- 2020–2024 Dean's Fellowship, UMD
- 2019–2020 University Fellowship, UMD
- 2018–2019 Serbian Government Scholarship for Gifted Students
- 2017–2018 Serbian Government Scholarship for Undergraduate Students
- 2016 Erasmus+ Scholarship
- 2014–2015 Woodhouse Grove School Academic Scholarship
- 2013–2014 The Headmasters' and Headmistresses' Conference (HMC) Projects in Central and Eastern Europe Scholarship

Awards and Honors

- 2023 Howard Lasnik Award for Distinguished Teaching by a Graduate Student

2022 Charles E. Townsend Memorial Award for outstanding scientific contribution to the Slavic Linguistics Society

Teaching & Advising

PH.D. THESES (committee member)

in progress Abdullah Alasmari, *Adjectives in Hijazi Arabic: A morphosyntactic analysis*. Georgetown University. COMMITTEE: Ahmad Alqassas, **Maša Bešlin**, Matthew Hewett, Ruth Kramer

INSTRUCTION

SPRING & FALL 2026 **LING 5127 Generative Syntax I**, Georgetown U.
DUTIES: designing and teaching an introductory graduate class with 15-20 students, mentoring the students on their final squibs, grading, office hours

FALL 2025 **LING 8133 Locality: From syntax to the interfaces**, Georgetown U.
DUTIES: designing and leading a graduate seminar with 5 students, mentoring the students on their final research papers, grading, office hours

JULY 2025 **Introduction to Generative Syntax**, NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive and Linguistic Studies
DUTIES: teaching an introductory class with 80 students, office hours

FALL 2022 **LING 420 Word Formation**, University of Maryland
DUTIES: designing and teaching a undergraduate seminar with 15 students, mentoring the students on their final papers, grading, office hours

JANUARY & JULY 2022 **Introduction to Generative Syntax**, NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive and Linguistic Studies, with Dr. Paulina Lyskawa
DUTIES: teaching an introductory class with 60-80 students, office hours

ASSISTANTSHIP

FALL 2024 **LING 240 Language and Mind**, University of Maryland
DUTIES: preparing materials, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Margaret Antonisse

JULY 2022 **Verb-initial languages** (*emphasis on Austronesian and Mayan*), The 4th Crete Summer School of Linguistics (CreteLing)
DUTIES: preparing materials, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Maria Polinsky

SPRING 2022 **LING 312 Syntax II**, University of Maryland
DUTIES: preparing materials, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Omer Preminger

FALL 2021 **LING 311 Syntax I**, University of Maryland
DUTIES: preparing materials, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Tonia Bleam

JULY 2021 **Introduction to Generative Syntax**, NY-St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition and Culture
DUTIES: handling Zoom chat/issues, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Omer Preminger

SPRING 2021 **LING 200 Introductory Linguistics**, University of Maryland
DUTIES: leading 3 weekly discussion sections, grading, office hours
INSTRUCTOR: Dr. Tonia Bleam

Research Assistantship

- FALL 2024– Variation in Exeptive Structures NSF-funded project
SPRING 2025 PIs: Dr. Maria Polinsky & Dr. Eric Potsdam
DUTIES: mentoring students in conducting fieldwork and writing up their findings on Thai, Korean, and Hindi exeptive constructions
- SPRING 2023 Variation in Exeptive Structures NSF-funded project
PIs: Dr. Maria Polinsky & Dr. Eric Potsdam
DUTIES: investigating the lexical, morphological, and syntactic properties of exeptives in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian (native) and K'iche' (fieldwork)

Schools and Workshops

- 2024 *NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive, and Linguistic Studies*
2023 *NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive, and Linguistic Studies*
2023 *Eastern Generative Grammar Summer School*, University of Novi Sad
2022 *The 4th Crete Summer School of Linguistics*, University of Crete
2021 *Eastern Generative Grammar Summer School*, online
2021 *NY-St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition and Culture*, online
2021 *Ri K'iche' Tijob'al Keb' Tz'i'*, online intensive 2-week course in K'iche', co-organized by UMD, University of Toronto and Wuqu' Kawoq
2020 *Kab'lajuj Ey 2020*, intensive 2-week course in Kaqchikel at the UMD Language Science Center's Guatemala Field Station in Patzún, Guatemala
2019 *Introduction to Statistics: R*, University of Novi Sad
2018 *Eastern Generative Grammar Summer School*, University of Banja Luka
2018 *6th Novi Sad Workshop on Psycholinguistic, Neurolinguistic and Clinical Linguistic Research*, University of Novi Sad
2017 *Eastern Generative Grammar Summer School*, Palacký University Olomouc
2017 *Introduction to Neurolinguistics*, University of Novi Sad

Service

REVIEWING

- JOURNALS Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy, University of Novi Sad, Catalan Journal of Linguistics, Folia Linguistica, Glossa: A journal of general linguistics, Journal of Slavic Linguistics, Linguistica Brunensia, Linguistic Inquiry
- BOOK Advances in Formal Slavic Linguistics 2023, 2025, Language Science Press
- CHAPTERS Cambridge Handbook of Comparative Syntax, Cambridge University Press
Semantics of Slavic Languages, Language Science Press
- CONFERENCES Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics (FASL 34 & 35)
Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17)
Syntax, Phonology, and Language Analysis (SinFonIJA 14, 16, 17 & 19)
The Society for the Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas Annual Meeting (SSILA 2025 & 2026)
West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 44)

OTHER SERVICE

- 2022– Proofreader for Language Science Press
- 2025 Member of the Department Framing Committee, Georgetown University
- 2024 Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2024* in honor of Masha Polinsky, UMD
- 2023 Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2023* in honor of Howard Lasnik, UMD
- 2022 Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2020(+2)* in honor of Norbert Hornstein, UMD
- 2022 Volunteer at *Maryland Day*, open house at UMD for the local community
- 2022 Proctor for the *North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad*
- 2021–2023 Student Representative for the Linguistics department, Dean’s Graduate Advisory Board, UMD
- 2021 Co-organizer for *Syntax, Phonology and Language Analysis 14 (SinFonIJA 14)*, University of Novi Sad (online)
- 2020–2021 Co-organizer, General Linguistics Lab Meeting, UMD
- 2018 Co-author and coordinator of the *Universal Grammar and Language Ability* workshop at the International Festival of Science and Education, University of Novi Sad

Other Work Experience

- 2015– Freelance translator English>Serbian, Spanish>Serbian, Serbian>English
- 2018 Interpreter (Spanish>Serbian, Serbian>Spanish) at *Koteks Viscofan* in Novi Sad, Serbia
- 2016–2019 Tutor for the courses English grammar 3, English Grammar 4, Generative Syntax 1 and Generative Syntax 2 at the University of Novi Sad
- 2015–2018 Freelance language teacher for English and Spanish

Professional Membership

- 2022– Society for the Study of Indigenous Languages of the Americas (SSILA)
- 2020– Linguistic Society of America (LSA)
- 2020– Slavic Linguistics Society (SLS)

Technical Skills

MS Office, Praat, PsychoPy, SPSS, L^AT_EX

Languages

- native* Serbian (Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian)
- fluent* English, Spanish
- beginner* German
- fieldwork* K’iche’, Kaqchikel

References (in order)

Professor Maria Polinsky

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Professor David Embick

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Professor Norbert Hornstein

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Associate Professor Tanja Milićev

University of Novi Sad
Dr Zorana Đinđića 2,
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Dr. Tonia Bleam

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